

Return to Stratford



HOME STUDY

Shakespeare continued to write for about two years after his return to Stratford. He visited London from time to time to work with John Fletcher on the three plays *Henry VIII*, *Two Noble Kinsmen*, and a lost play called *Cardenio*. Shakespeare's fellow playwrights, including Ben Jonson, also visited him at New Place.

LAST LINES

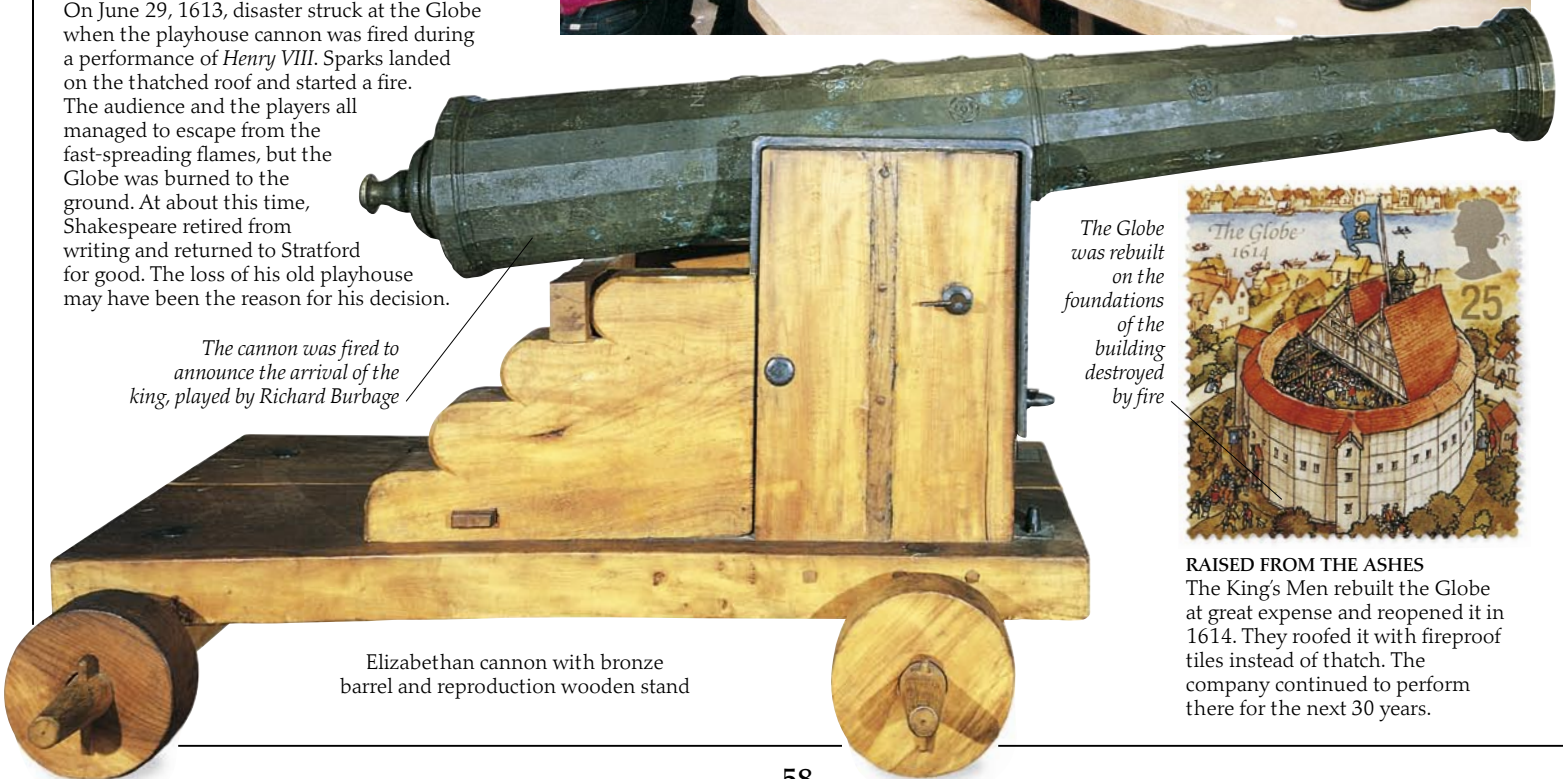
In 1613, Shakespeare wrote his last lines for the theater in the play *Two Noble Kinsmen*. The scenes written by Shakespeare stand out because he used language in a more complicated way than Fletcher did. This little-known and rarely performed play tells the story of two friends, Palamon and Arcite. The characters, shown here in a production of the play at the modern Globe theater, both fall for the beautiful Emilia, and rivalry in love turns them into bitter enemies.



SOUND EFFECT BACKFIRES

On June 29, 1613, disaster struck at the Globe when the playhouse cannon was fired during a performance of *Henry VIII*. Sparks landed on the thatched roof and started a fire. The audience and the players all managed to escape from the fast-spreading flames, but the Globe was burned to the ground. At about this time, Shakespeare retired from writing and returned to Stratford for good. The loss of his old playhouse may have been the reason for his decision.

The cannon was fired to announce the arrival of the king, played by Richard Burbage



Elizabethan cannon with bronze barrel and reproduction wooden stand

The Globe was rebuilt on the foundations of the building destroyed by fire



RAISED FROM THE ASHES
The King's Men rebuilt the Globe at great expense and reopened it in 1614. They roofed it with fireproof tiles instead of thatch. The company continued to perform there for the next 30 years.